

Soul Winning, Vocation, and Occupation

Praying in Tongues Restores the Discerning Mind of Christ

Turn to Matthew 5. Then we will go to Ephesians 4, Genesis 4, and Third John. At least I have great faith that we will make it that far!

We have been studying prayer, particularly Holy Ghost-empowered prayer through the supernatural diversities of tongues. The Church has been confused about tongues because it has tried to put the same rules on every diversity.

We found four basic operations. First is tongues for personal edification. Second is tongues presented in the public assembly for interpretation. Third is tongues extending into the deep intercessional groanings of the Spirit, empowering a believer to stand in the gap for his life, family, city, nation, or world. Fourth is tongues as a sign to the unbeliever, when the Holy Spirit creates through you an earthly language you have never learned.

Suppose I stood before a Russian-speaking crowd that knew no English, my translator suddenly became unavailable, and tongues as a sign to the unbeliever came upon me. If I began preaching in Russian and the altars filled, then the people learned that I had never known Russian, that would be this sign personified.

I wish I could operate in tongues for interpretation, deep intercession, or the unbeliever whenever I chose, but those operate as the Spirit wills. Only tongues for personal edification can be exercised at my will as often as I please. The other gifts flow through you for the edification of others; this one flows to you for your own edification. God has therefore made you steward of its operation. As long as you choose to pray, the Holy Spirit remains with you and creates that supernatural language for your edification.

Extended prayer begins a journey into God. The mind of Christ in you may have been beaten into a resting place by false doctrine or contrary circumstances until it no longer discerns doctrine, business decisions, or the things entering your life. I am not talking about feeling good and speaking a few words in church, or praying two minutes while driving to work. I mean sitting down and developing a rapport with the Holy Spirit, disciplining your flesh to remain in His presence until the mind of Christ is dislodged and begins discerning everything that enters your life.

Sanctification Reaches Flesh, Soul, and Doctrine

The Spirit begins mortification and sanctification in three areas: body, soul, and spirit.

First, He separates you from filthiness of the flesh. You cannot remain in an increasingly edified state while habitually holding on to such things as drinking, smoking, and immorality.

Then He deals with filthiness of soul: hatred, strife, insolence, unforgiveness, and the destructive use of the tongue. If you choose habits that destroy your own body, you hurt yourself. When your tongue begins destroying other people, God makes it His business. This is why churches have so many problems: people never rise above the flesh. A person can sit in the front room and lick a spoon in the kitchen, especially when that tongue is turned against somebody else. But if you remain in prayer, He will sanctify you from it.

Third is filthiness of spirit. Do not misunderstand me. The born-again person is the righteousness of God in Christ and possesses His nature. Here I am speaking of feeding the inner man incorrect doctrine. The Spirit can purge you from that too.

When you pray in tongues, you speak mysteries. Hour after hour, you speak the mystery of everything Christ is in you, to you, and through you, the hope of glory.

For he that speaketh in an unknown tongue speaketh not unto men, but unto God: for no man understandeth him; howbeit in the spirit he speaketh mysteries.

When the mind of Christ comes forward, it begins discerning false doctrine presented to your spirit. John said that concerning those who would deceive us, the anointing abides within and teaches us. It bears witness to truth and cannot lie.

A human spirit and soul can be overpowered by dominant personalities and wrong doctrine until a person finally concedes, files the mind of Christ on a shelf, and believes, for example, that God sent disease to teach him something. But praying the mysteries of Christ causes the inner witness to become so strong that you can hardly sit under error.

After my first year praying in the Holy Ghost, I returned to some doctrinal circles I once ran with. As they preached, something inside me went dead. I wondered whether I had backslidden, because two years earlier I would have done cartwheels over the same message. What had happened was that the mind of Christ had come forward and was discerning what entered my life.

You need this discernment too. Do you enjoy making bad business deals? Do you enjoy repeatedly making wrong choices and only understanding them through hindsight? Wisdom says that, however busy the schedule, anyone who wants to begin this journey with God will make time to become acquainted with the Holy Spirit's operation.

Romans 8 says the Spirit helps our infirmities. God did not leave us hopeless in this flesh and under life's pressures. He sent the Holy Spirit to help us through life, sanctify us from flesh and worldliness, cleanse filthiness of soul, and make the mind of Christ so discerning that doctrine from hell cannot survive in us.

Every Believer's First Calling Is Soul Winning

The more I prayed in the Holy Ghost, the more my calling and ministry came forward. Because I am called to preach, that is what He developed in me. But what if you are not called to preach? What will prayer ultimately bring forward in your life?

Many have come to the Prayer Center believing they are called to the simplicity of giving, or gospel entrepreneurship. They believe their business ability exists so that one day they can write five-million-dollar checks and add countless souls to their heavenly account. I believe such a ministry exists. But only a small percentage of people operate at the highest level of enterprise; another group manages those fortunes, while others do the labor. A person cannot necessarily come from a weak background, pray for one year, and instantly become a great entrepreneur. When that does not happen, some throw up their arms and abandon prayer.

Let me encourage you. As you continue praying, God's direction comes forward in three areas. The more you give yourself to God, the more He gives Himself to you.

Your first calling is soul winning.

You may say, "I am called to be a mighty prophet, apostle, or evangelist. Honor me!" But when one unsaved person stands in the room with you, you may as well hang that mantle on a nail. God expects you to lead that person to Christ.

Jesus said in Matthew 5:

Ye are the salt of the earth: but if the salt have lost his savour, wherewith shall it be salted?

And again:

Ye are the light of the world. A city that is set on an hill cannot be hid.

You were not born again to be hidden under a bushel. You were made to give light to everyone in the house.

That is why I tell people not to ask me to perform their wedding until they hear what I have to say. Whatever they ask me to do, my first calling is soul winning. If they fill this building with unbelievers to watch a wedding, do they think I will not take a shot at my first calling? I will not conduct a funeral unless I am allowed to fulfill it either. Your first calling and mine is soul winning.

The Mill Became a Field for the First Calling

Before the Holy Ghost can train you in your vocation, He first works to make you a soul winner.

At the mill, seven men pulled chain with me, sorting and stacking boards. It was a rather mindless job, and I hated the whole business. Yet my first calling kept me energized. Anything that paused long enough for me to catch it received John 3:16.

I followed those men everywhere preaching the Gospel. I followed them into the smoke-filled break shack and breathed the cloud just to get another opportunity. I would provoke an argument and get all of them coming at me at once. I considered it good training, and God helped me.

In the first revival I brought to the city, every man on that chain except perhaps one attended. They had a deep respect for me and called me "Preach." I did not care whether the person was a coworker or a boss. That was my first calling.

Vocation Is Your Grace-Given Measure in Christ's Body

Your second calling is your vocation in the kingdom: the gift through which God has called you to serve the body of Christ.

Paul says in Ephesians 4:

I therefore, the prisoner of the Lord, beseech you that ye walk worthy of the vocation wherewith ye are called,
With all lowliness and meekness, with longsuffering, forbearing one another in love;
Endeavouring to keep the unity of the Spirit in the bond of peace.

There is one body, one Spirit, one hope of our calling, one Lord, one faith, one baptism, and one God and Father of all. Then verse 7 says:

But unto every one of us is given grace according to the measure of the gift of Christ.

You did not elect your calling. God separated you to it by grace. You did not decide what it would be; He did. By His unearned favor and election, He called you to fulfill your place in Christ's body.

A measure is part of a whole. The body of Christ is the whole, and your calling is one measure within it. Are you a foot, hand, eye, nose, ear, or mouth? Whatever your measure, all the measures working together form one devil-stopping, mountain-moving body of Christ.

Paul continues:

When he ascended up on high, he led captivity captive, and gave gifts unto men.

He gave apostles, prophets, evangelists, pastors, and teachers. First Corinthians 12 also names helps, governments, and diversities of tongues. If you pray in the Holy Ghost, He will develop your first calling and bring forward your vocation.

Occupation Is the Natural Work Born Into Your Design

Your third calling is your occupation. Genesis 4 describes the beginnings of different occupations:

And Adah bare Jabal: he was the father of such as dwell in tents, and of such as have cattle.

And his brother's name was Jubal: he was the father of all such as handle the harp and organ.

And Zillah, she also bare Tubal-cain, an instructor of every artificer in brass and iron.

Within humanity are different aptitudes for occupation. Some people love horticulture, plants, cattle, and horses. They would rather spend time with an animal than talk to you. That work is born in them.

Others have music in them. Jimmy Swaggart, Mickey Gilley, and Jerry Lee Lewis were cousins, and each seemed able simply to sit at a piano. Jerry Lee Lewis became a legend in rock music, Mickey Gilley in country, and Jimmy Swaggart in Gospel music.

Others are craftsmen and professional instructors, skilled with metal, computers, and design. Their aptitude came forward as part of their occupation. It is not unusual for vocation and occupation to work together.

Extended prayer does not bring forward only spiritual things. The Holy Spirit develops your occupation, your vocation, and your first calling. Unless all three come forward in divine order, you will not experience the wholeness John desired when he wrote:

Beloved, I wish above all things that thou mayest prosper and be in health, even as thy soul prospereth.

Prosperity of Soul Includes the Emotions

The soul includes mind, will, intellect, and emotions. John desires the prosperity of all these faculties, especially our emotions.

People object when I say emotions can be stronger than the will. We are free moral agents and can choose, but if we never turn our emotions, we usually return to the behavior we decided against. Around New Year's, people decide to lose weight or make other changes. The will remains strong for a while. Then one morning they no longer want to do what they willed, and the emotions defeat the decision. Over the long term, people generally do what they want to do. If you can turn the emotions, you can turn anything.

What good is a healthy body if you violently hate your occupation? You hate getting up, hate going to work, and every minute spent earning money is drudgery. What good is money without health, health without provision, or either one when you hate what you do to earn your living?

As you give yourself to the Holy Ghost, praying the mind of Christ, He comes forward and rejects inputs that are not of God in your first calling, vocation, and occupation. He wants your soul to prosper.

Before I discovered my occupation and vocation were the same, I worked dead-end, mindless, minimum-wage jobs. I would do so again if necessary to feed my family. If your family needs provision, the choice is no longer yours. But a higher walk becomes possible when everything God placed in you is allowed to come forward.

Perhaps you have not reached the occupation you love because you have not yet received the information or direction needed to do so. How can the soul prosper when you hate your work so much that even fellowship with God seems to wait for the weekend?

It Is Never Too Late to Pursue the Work You Were Made to Do

When God called me to preach, I was working at the mill. He visited me in a vision because I did not yet have enough Word, but my heart pursued Him so intensely that some days I could hardly live. He used that heart to teach me and make a way.

The mill told me, "When you come back, we will give you a job." They would do so because I worked ten-hour days, volunteered Saturdays when the boss was in difficulty, sometimes worked sixteen hours, and never missed a day through sickness. When I asked for time to attend a Pentecostal meeting many miles away, they gave it because I normally produced twice what the sinners produced. My job served my first calling while God developed my occupation.

You are never too old to begin. I am fifty-two. If I learned today that I was meant to be a doctor and truly desired it, I would investigate every grant, reduce my house and expenses, sell a car if necessary, and ask my family to walk with me while my occupation developed. If it took ten years of school, twelve years from now I would aim to be the best doctor I could be. I might work until eighty, but that would be all right because I am going to become eighty anyway.

When your soul prospers and you cannot wait to get out of bed and go to work, enormous pressure comes off your body. Tears of grief and tears of joy do not produce the same effects. Hatred of every working hour places a different pressure on life than joy in one's calling.

What You Call a Hobby May Reveal Your Occupation

Some of you love horses, cattle, gardens, and growing things. You thank God for plants. Your house is full of them, and you talk about them to your neighbors. Yet every day you go to work as a computer programmer and hate touching the keyboard. You feel alive only when the workday ends and you return to your plants.

Here is the odd thing: you call the plants your hobby and computer programming your occupation. Perhaps you should be paid for the thing you love. What you consistently gravitate toward may reveal your occupation. Somebody supplies the materials for your hobby; why could

that supplier not eventually be you?

Suppose you earn a large salary programming but discover horticulture is truly in you. Gather your family and ask whether you can reduce expenses, use an older vehicle, and live on less while you take a position at a greenhouse and study horticulture at night. The reduction would not feel like defeat. You would spend the day with plants and the evening learning about diseases and exotic flowers. Your days would be full of life.

As you grow in knowledge and character, the greenhouse owner may want to retire. You may obtain financing and buy the business. Eventually you might acquire other greenhouses, train people, franchise the work, write about horticulture, and lecture around the world. Through it all, your first calling could operate more effectively:

"I attribute my success to Jesus Christ and the wisdom He placed in me. He created plants, gave me understanding of them, and enabled me to support Gospel work."

Giving also becomes easier when you loved earning what you give. It is harder to release a day's wages when you dreaded every hour required to earn them.

Prayer can bring all this forward. If God intends you to operate at the highest level of enterprise, He will build the character necessary to win. Even a ministry without a personal relationship with Him remains second-rate.

When Vocation and Occupation United, Work Became Life-Giving

When my occupation and vocation became the same, the mill workers said, "Preach, you will be back. Your job will be waiting."

I told them I did not think so. Within months of entering full-time ministry, God provided a new Volkswagen van, paid for from the showroom floor. Although private vehicles were not supposed to enter mill property, I drove that van to the break-shack door where I had contended for the faith.

I called the men over and said, "Look what God gave me!"

"He gave you a new car, Preach?"

"He gave me a new car, and He has also provided for my wife, a motor home, and another house."

Now my occupation and vocation ran in the same stream. I sprang out of bed each morning. Before that, only the opportunity to administer my first calling at the mill had put spring into my step. That would have been enough to carry me while providing for my family. But now my hours could be given to prayer, reading, and ministry. I felt as though I had gone to heaven, and the joy did not diminish.

The Gift Was Given to Serve People, Not Personal Comfort

In India, Augie kept filling our room with people who needed ministry. We arrived in Bombay at two in the morning, and he brought people into our room until six. I ministered to them one after another.

During one two-day period, I rode overnight trains both nights and ministered for twelve hours. Augie filled the remaining time with perhaps forty people who needed individual ministry. I nearly complained.

The Lord said, "For this cause I gave you your gift. How would you like not to have it?"

I said, "Send the next person in."

I could not live indefinitely at that pace, but I could finish the three-week course. When you are in your occupation, the burden affects you differently. You do not need to feel guilty because you love plants, music, cattle, or whatever work was born in you. Every day can be ordered by God and filled with life-giving purpose.

Divine Order Places Ministry Before Money

The Holy Spirit delivers us from filthiness of flesh, soul, and doctrine, and He brings us into our first calling, vocation, and occupation.

People applaud when someone moves across the nation for a twenty-thousand-dollar raise. But if he says, "I am moving because there is a church there that can train me to walk in the Spirit," they may call it a cult. That is how the world thinks.

Divine order is different. First comes soul winning. Second comes vocation. Third comes occupation. If occupation is placed ahead of vocation, God cannot fully lead you in it, because you, your work, and your family were all meant to minister at His feet.

Stand, and let us worship God.